HR-201 Attendance and Working Hours

Policy ID: HR-201 Version: 4.0 Classification: Internal
Effective Date: 1 January 2026 Owner: People Operations
Applies to: All permanent and fixed-term employees

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1 Purpose and Scope

This policy sets out the company's expectations for working hours and attendance. It explains the standard working week, how attendance is recorded, how additional hours are treated, and what employees must do when they are unable to attend work.

The policy applies to all permanent and fixed-term employees. Contractors and agency workers follow the terms of their engagement, except where this policy is referenced in that agreement.

Where an entity annex applies to an employee, the annex takes precedence over this policy wherever the two conflict.

2 Working Hours

2.1 Standard Working Hours

The standard working week is thirty-seven and a half hours, worked Monday to Friday. Normal office hours are from nine in the morning until half past five in the afternoon, which includes an unpaid lunch break of one hour.

All employees are expected to be contactable and available for meetings during core hours, which run from ten in the morning until four in the afternoon. Outside core hours, employees may vary their start and finish times by up to one hour with their manager's agreement, provided the full weekly hours are worked and business needs are met.

Part-time employees work the hours set out in their contract of employment. Where a part-time pattern does not cover the full core hours, the manager and employee must agree in writing which hours are fixed and which are flexible, and record that agreement with People Operations.

2.2 Rest Breaks

Employees are entitled to an uninterrupted rest break of twenty minutes when the working day exceeds six hours. This break is unpaid and is taken away from the workstation.

Where the working day exceeds ten hours, a second unpaid break of twenty minutes applies. Breaks are not cumulative and cannot be taken at the start or end of the day to shorten it.

A daily rest period of at least eleven consecutive hours applies between the end of one working day and the start of the next.

2.3 Overtime

Overtime is any work carried out beyond the contracted weekly hours at the manager's request. Overtime must be agreed in advance; hours worked without prior agreement are not treated as overtime and are not compensated.

Employees at grades 1 to 4 receive time off in lieu at the rate of one hour for each hour worked. Time off in lieu must be taken within three months of being earned, after which it lapses.

Employees at grades 5 and above are not eligible for overtime compensation. Their contracts reflect the expectation that hours will vary with business need.

2.4 Time Recording

Employees record their working time weekly in the human resources system by the end of the working day on Friday. Managers approve submitted time by the following Tuesday.

Time records are the basis for overtime calculation, leave accrual and absence reporting. Persistent failure to submit time records is treated as a conduct matter under section 5.

3 Attendance

3.1 Attendance Expectations

Employees are expected to attend work punctually and to be present for all scheduled hours. Where an employee cannot attend, they must notify their manager directly by telephone or message before the start of their working day, and in any case no later than one hour after it.

Notification by a third party is accepted only where the employee is physically unable to make contact. A message left with a colleague is not notification; it must reach the manager or, where the manager is unavailable, that manager's own manager.

Employees must give the expected duration of the absence where it is known, and contact their manager again on each subsequent day of absence unless a longer period has been agreed.

3.2 Unauthorised Absence

Absence that has not been notified in accordance with section 3.1, and for which no acceptable explanation is given on the employee's return, is treated as unauthorised.

Unauthorised absence is unpaid and may be treated as a conduct matter. A first instance is normally addressed informally by the manager; repeated instances are escalated under the disciplinary procedure.

An absence of five consecutive working days with no contact is treated as potential abandonment of employment, and People Operations will write to the employee's home address before any further step is taken.

3.3 Lateness

Arrival after the agreed start time, or after the start of core hours where a flexible pattern applies, is recorded as lateness. Occasional lateness is expected and is not of itself a concern.

Where lateness exceeds three occasions in a rolling month, the manager discusses it with the employee and records the discussion. Continued lateness after that discussion is addressed under the disciplinary procedure.

3.4 Return to Work

On the first day back after any absence, the manager holds a return-to-work discussion with the employee. The discussion covers the reason for absence, whether the employee is fit to resume full duties, and whether any adjustment is needed.

The discussion is recorded in the human resources system. Its purpose is support rather than investigation, and a record of it is not of itself a disciplinary step.

4 Related Policies

Annual leave is covered by HR-202. Flexible working arrangements are covered by HR-204. Remote and hybrid working is covered by HR-206.

Questions about notice periods, parental leave, pensions or expenses are not covered by this policy or by any other in this set, and must be directed to an HR business partner.

5 Non-Compliance

Failure to follow this policy may be treated as a conduct matter under the disciplinary procedure. Managers who do not apply it consistently are accountable for that through their own objectives.

6 Records

Attendance and time records are retained for six years from the end of the leave year to which they relate, after which they are deleted. Return-to-work records are retained for three years.

7 Review

This policy is reviewed every two years, or earlier where legislation or business practice changes. The owner named above is accountable for the review.